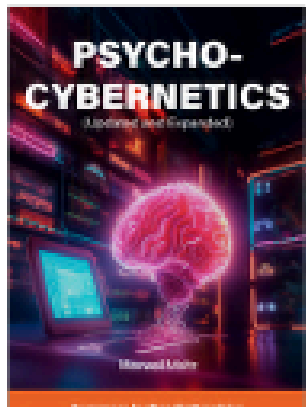




PSYCHO-CYBERNETICS

(Updated and Expanded)

Maxwell Maltz



The Big “So What”

In this book, Maxwell Maltz applies cybernetics—traditionally used to study feedback systems in machines—to understanding the human mind and personal transformation. He offers a step-by-step guide to reshape your self-image, thereby reprogram your mind, break free from self-imposed limitations and achieve success in any area of your life.



What is Psycho-Cybernetics?



Cybernetics is the study of systems that automatically achieve goals using feedback.

- Just as a missile uses feedback to correct its course and hit its target, the human brain also uses feedback to adjust actions and achieve goals. Dr. Maltz applied these principles to the mind, showing how our brain can be programmed to achieve success and personal growth.



The brain is like an advanced computer. Like a computer, the brain processes experiences and adjusts actions based on feedback. However, the brain is far more complex, since it's powered by human creativity, beliefs, and imagination.

- The conscious mind is our thinking mind. It consciously analyzes inputs and can choose to accept, reject, or create ideas.
- Our subconscious mind, on the other hand, accepts ideas without question. Such ideas are imprinted by the conscious mind through thoughts or vivid imagination. The more often an idea is repeated with strong emotional responses, the deeper the imprint.

KEY QUOTES

“The self-image is the key to human personality and human behavior. Change the self-image and you change the personality and the behavior.”

“Man is by nature a goalstriving being...Thus true success and true happiness not only go together but each enhances the other.”

“Psycho-Cybernetics does not say that man is a machine. Rather, it says that man has a machine that he uses.”

“The more that is learned about the human brain, the more closely it resembles—insofar as function is concerned—a servo-mechanism.”

- Once these beliefs or goals are programmed into the subconscious, they shape our actions and responses, often without our conscious awareness.



The subconscious mind has a Creative Mechanism which functions like a goal-seeking system. It doesn't question or judge the goals it receives, be it positive or negative. It simply follows those instructions, calibrating our actions/responses until it achieves the goal.

- When we focus on clear, positive goals, our mind works as a Success Mechanism to help us achieve those goals. When we focus on negative/limiting beliefs, our brain acts as a Failure Mechanism, steering us toward those undesired outcomes.
- The brain uses two types of feedback systems to reach goals:
 - (i) When it receives a *clear, specific goal*, it acts like guided missile to direct our actions/responses toward that goal.
 - (ii) When we lack the direct experiences to achieve a goal, the brain can come up with *creative solutions* through imagination and mental rehearsals (elaborated below).



The Power of Self-Image



As a plastic surgeon, Dr. Maltz noticed that patients often experienced a strong shift in psychology and behaviors after changing their physical appearance. Yet, they seldom experienced lasting happiness. It led him to realize that true transformation comes from within, not from physical or external changes.



Self-image is the mental blueprint of who we believe we are. It is built from our past experiences, successes, failures, and beliefs.

- It is like an invisible guide directing your subconscious mind, influencing everything you do. It controls your thoughts, actions, feelings, and even your abilities, ultimately determining your results.
 - (i) If you see yourself as a failure, you will unconsciously find ways to fail, no matter how hard you try.

KEY QUOTES

"This Creative Mechanism within you is impersonal. It will work automatically and impersonally to achieve goals of success and happiness, or unhappiness and failure, depending on the goals that you yourself set for it."

"When you do see a thing clearly in your mind, the creative Success Mechanism within you takes over and does the job much better than you could do it by conscious effort, or 'willpower.'"

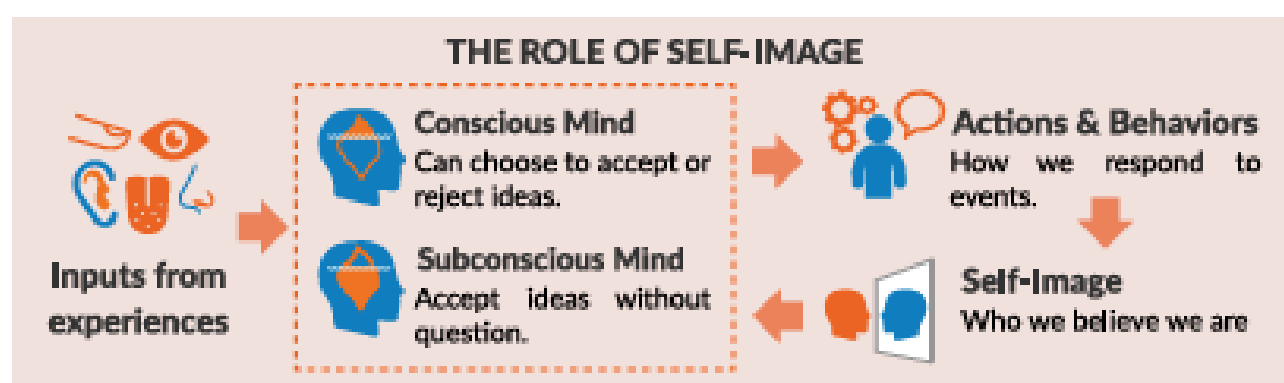
"A plastic surgeon does not simply alter a man's face. He alters the man's inner self."

"The self-image is a premise, a base, or a foundation upon which your entire personality, your behavior, and even your circumstances are built."

"All your actions, feelings, behaviors—even your abilities—are always consistent with this self-image...you will 'act like' the sort of person you conceive yourself to be."

(ii) If you see yourself as capable and successful, your actions and experiences will align with that belief, creating a reinforcing cycle of positive outcomes.

- To achieve lasting behavioral change, you must first change your self-image—and it can be changed.
 - Positive thinking alone won't work if you hold a negative belief about yourself. But once your self-image changes, new behaviors come naturally and effortlessly.
 - Psychologist Prescott Lecky found that students who improved their self-image saw significant academic improvement, with one student going from failing to achieving A-grades.



♥ A flawed self-image often leads to “imaginary ugliness,” where people feel unattractive despite their actual appearance. The solution is to build a healthy self-image, not to alter your physical appearance. In the next section, we will break down how to do so by activating the Success Mechanism and overcoming the Failure Mechanism.

🧠 The ideas in this book cannot be understood intellectually; they must be experienced. It takes at least 21 days of consistent mental rehearsal and visualization to reshape a self-image. So, make sure you practice the tips and ideas below without judgment, so as to experience the effects for yourself.



Living a More Successful, Fulfilling Life

To live a successful and fulfilling life, you need a realistic self-image—to recognize both your strengths and weaknesses without exaggeration or denial, so you can express your true self with confidence.

KEY QUOTES

“Positive thinking” cannot be used effectively as a patch or a crutch to the same old self-image.”

“The self-image sets the boundaries of individual accomplishment. It defines what you can and cannot do. Expand the self-image and you expand the ‘area of the possible.’”

“To find life reasonably satisfying, you must have an adequate and realistic selfimage that you can live with. You must find your self acceptable to ‘you.’”

“You can neither prove nor disprove the ideas and concepts described in this book with intellectual argument, or simply by talking about them. You can prove them to yourself by doing them and judging results for yourself.”

unrealistic expectations, a negative self-image, or perfectionism. Acknowledge the frustration and adjust your expectations.

- Aggressiveness: The desire to control, dominate, or forcefully achieve goals can lead to irritability, health issues, and strained relationships. Find healthy outlets (e.g. exercise, writing) to release the tension.
- Insecurity: Self-doubt, comparison, and unrealistic standards can lead us to avoid challenges or overextend ourselves. Rather than seek perfection or prove your superiority, embrace imperfection as part of continuous growth.
- Loneliness: Fear of rejection or low self-worth can lead to a cycle of withdrawal from others and further disconnection. Actively engage with others even if it feels uncomfortable initially.
- Uncertainty: When we feel lost or unclear about our direction, we might feel paralyzed or start blaming others. Instead of avoiding mistakes, seek to learn from them instead.
- Resentment: When we blame others for our failures, we get trapped in a cycle of self-pity, blame and negative thinking. Forgive, let go of past grievances, and move forward.
- Emptiness: We feel unfulfilled and apathetic when we pursue goals that are misaligned with our values or emotional needs. To regain purpose and fulfillment, refocus on goals that align with your true desires and values.



Using Imagination & Visualization



Mental imagery is a powerful tool for guiding the brain toward a goal. When we visualize success or achievement, it activates the brain's Creative Mechanism to make that outcome a reality.

- The subconscious mind doesn't distinguish between real versus vividly-imagined experiences. You can use visualization and imagination to plant new goals or "memories" to guide your brain, build skills, and reshape your self-image.
- For example, under hypnosis, people can act in ways that defy their actual abilities because they believe the hypnotist's

KEY QUOTES

"The answer to aggression is not to eradicate it, but to understand it, and provide proper and appropriate channels for its expression."

"Trying to stand on the top of a pinnacle is insecure. Mentally, get down off your high horse and you will feel more secure."

"The person who is alienated from his real self has cut himself off from the basic and fundamental "contact" with life."

"If we wait until we are absolutely certain and sure before we act, we will never do anything."

"The person in whom the capacity to enjoy is dead can find enjoyment in nothing."

"A human being always acts and feels and performs in accordance with what he imagines to be true about himself and his environment."

"The power of hypnosis is the power of belief."

suggestions. A person with normal hearing may behave as if they were deaf, or a champion weightlifter might struggle to lift something as light as a pencil. In short, our imagination or belief can override our physical abilities.



By vividly visualizing specific goals or scenarios, you can program your brain to achieve them.

- The nervous system responds based on what the brain perceives—regardless of whether it's real. For instance, if you believe that a person in a bear costume is a real bear, your body will experience the same fear response as if it were facing a real threat. Through vivid visualization, you can create "synthetic experiences" to get your brain and body to respond as if your imagined goals are already happening.
- By using mental rehearsals, you can practice a behavior or skill without physical effort. In a famous experiment, basketball players who visualized free throws improved almost as much as those who practiced physically. Similarly, salespeople who mentally rehearsed their sales scenarios increased their sales performance by 150-400%.
- Many successful leaders also used visualization to achieve their goals. Napoleon visualized his military strategies before executing them, and business figures like Conrad Hilton and Henry Kaiser regularly imagined their successes before they materialized.



Daily visualization exercise. Set aside 5-30 minutes each day to vividly picture yourself achieving specific goals that align with your true self and potential.

- Focus on the steps, emotions, and sensations involved in reaching those goals. Or, focus on the person you wish to be, seeing how your ideal self thinks, feels, and behaves.
- Such exercises create new "memories" in your brain to cumulatively build a new self-image. After some time, you might find yourself spontaneously acting in line with those images.

KEY QUOTES

"We act, or fail to act, not because of 'will,' as is so commonly believed, but because of imagination."

"You act, and feel, not according to what things are really like, but according to the image your mind holds of what they are like."

"Hold a picture of yourself long and steadily enough in your mind's eye and you will be drawn toward it."
—Dr. Harry Emerson Fosdick

"Our aim is to find the real self, and to bring our mental images of ourselves more in line with the objects represented by our goals."

"You must first clearly see a thing in your mind before you can do it."
—Alex Morrison



Using Your Conscious Mind and Rational Thinking



Rational thinking is the process of analyzing situations logically and responding to them with clear, objective reasoning. It's key to manage our feelings so (i) emotional impulses like fear or frustration cannot derail our progress, and (ii) we can intentionally shape the thoughts and beliefs that drive the Creative Mechanism.



Many of us focus too much on past mistakes and the fear of failure.

- This drains our confidence and makes even small challenges seem overwhelming. Moreover, the Creative Mechanism responds to the data we feed it—if we focus on failure, it will lead us toward more failures. Learn from your mistakes, then let go and move forward, keeping your attention on past successes and future goals.



Rational thought helps us critically evaluate beliefs, so we can make decisions based on facts, not misconceptions or fears.

- Prescott Lecky emphasized 2 key beliefs for personal growth: (i) that you are capable and independent, and (ii) that your inner dignity should never be compromised.
- Whenever you feel inadequate or unworthy, challenge yourself by asking: Is this belief based on facts, or is it an assumption?



Use emotions like anger, indignation, and desire to motivate yourself to break free from limiting beliefs and achieve success.



Once you've set clear goals and laid the groundwork, trust your automatic mechanism to handle the rest, rather than consciously trying to control every detail.



Using Your Subconscious Mind & Unleashing Creative Insight



The subconscious mind is a powerful tool for creative problem-solving.

- Often, our best insights come when we step away from the problem, and allow the subconscious mind to "incubate" or connect ideas without our conscious effort.

KEY QUOTES

"A person has to start in the present to acquire some maturity so that the future may be better than the past."

"The minute that we change our minds and stop giving power to the past, the past with its mistakes loses its power over us."

"Ideas are changed, not by "will," but by other ideas."

"Feelings are the soil that thoughts and ideas grow in."

"We get into trouble when we either neglect to use conscious thinking in the way that it is meant to be used, or when we attempt to use it in a way that it was never meant to be used."

"You must have a clear mental picture of the correct thing before you can do it successfully."

- For example, Charles Darwin's key idea for *The Origin of Species* emerged during a carriage ride, after months of analysis. Philosopher and author Bertrand Russell often worked intensely on a complex problem, then took a break and "passed" the issue to the subconscious mind to continue working on it.



Overthinking blocks this natural creative process. For example, a pianist who overanalyzes each note may struggle to play fluidly, and people who overthink social situations tend to come across as being stiff and unnatural.



Our conscious brain is good for analyzing problems, but creative problem-solving is best left to the subconscious mind. To unleash its full potential, use these 5 rules to incorporate relaxation and detachment into problem-solving.

- Worry before, not after, making a decision: Address risks and concerns beforehand, but once a decision is made, stop worrying and start engaging the task/problem fully.
- It's ok to plan for the future, but don't get lost in past or future concerns. Instead, focus on the present.
- Do one thing at a time to become calmer and more productive. Don't multitask.
- Sleep on it: When you're stuck, take a break and let your subconscious process the problem in the background. Thomas Edison often reviewed problems just before going to bed at night or before taking a nap, so his subconscious could work on solutions while he slept.
- Stay relaxed while working: Tension and stress block creativity. Consciously relax throughout the day to reduce stress and enhance creativity. Every hour or so, take a minute to release tension from your body and mind, and to consciously relax. Recall the feeling of your arms, legs, back, and face when you're completely at ease, and deepen the sense of calm by saying "I feel more and more relaxed."

KEY QUOTES

"We become nervous because we are trying to do the impossible, and thereby making futility and frustration inevitable."

"By relaxing, and maintaining a relaxed attitude, you remove those excessive states of concern, tension, and anxiety, which interfere with the efficient operation of your Creative Mechanism."

"Make long-range plans for tomorrow. But don't try to live in tomorrow, or in the past."

"The truth is: We can only do one thing at a time...When we work with this attitude, we are relaxed, we are free from the feelings of hurry and anxiety, and we are able to concentrate and think at our best."



Applying the Happiness Formula



Happiness is a mental state that brings many benefits, from better health to improved relationships and success. However, there are several common misconceptions that lead people astray:

- Happiness is not a destination: Many people think they'll be happy once they achieve certain goals or milestones. True happiness comes from within and can be accessed *right now*.
- Happiness is not selfish: True happiness often involves helping others. However, it's not about self-sacrifice, even though it feels good to be valued and needed by others.
- Happiness is a habit: It can be cultivated through daily practice, by consciously choosing positive thoughts and maintaining a positive outlook every day.



Happiness is an internal state shaped by our ideas, thoughts, and attitudes, not external circumstances. To cultivate happiness:

- Own your happiness. Don't give away your power by allowing others' opinions to dictate your happiness. When you're calm and at peace within, happiness becomes your natural state.
- Live in the present to foster inner peace. Don't dwell on past mistakes or worry about the future.
- Happiness can't be forced. Rather than strive for happiness, do the things that bring joy and fulfillment, and allow happiness to come naturally as a byproduct of a balanced, purposeful life.
- Choose your response to negativity: You can't avoid unpleasant events in life, but you can choose how to respond to them. Self-pity or resentment only worsens the situation. Instead, focus on a positive goal and actively pursue it.
- Happiness is a choice, so focus on positive thoughts regardless of what each day brings.

KEY QUOTES

"We think better, perform better, feel better, and are healthier when we are happy. Even our physical sense organs work better."

*"Most people are about as happy as they make up their minds to be."
—Abraham Lincoln*

*"Happiness is purely internal. It is produced, not by objects, but by ideas, thoughts, and attitudes which can be developed and constructed by the individual's own activities, irrespective of the environment."
—Dr. Matthew N. Chappell*

*"The measure of mental health is the disposition to find good everywhere."
—Ralph Waldo Emerson*



Releasing Inhibitions



True personality comes from within, as a reflection of your unique self. But for many people, it's hidden beneath layers of self-doubt, fear, and limiting beliefs.

- Over-inhibition is the suppression of natural impulses, often driven by fear of failure or self-criticism. We hold ourselves back, leading to missed opportunities and under-achievement, such as withholding ideas in meetings out of fear of judgment.
- Self-criticism can magnify minor mistakes to make them seem insurmountable. Stutterers, for instance, spoke more naturally when they couldn't hear their own voice (thereby removing self-critical feedback).



To unlock your true personality, become aware of your own thoughts, feelings and actions, without being excessively concerned about others' opinions.

- Ironically, you make the best impression when you stop trying too hard. When you express yourself authentically, you resonate more with others. But when you inhibit yourself due to fear or insecurity, you come across as inauthentic, which can be off-putting.
- Don't overthink public speaking or performances. Prepare thoroughly, then trust yourself to perform naturally and spontaneously.



Use these exercises to overcome inhibition:

- Speak louder in daily interactions, without shouting. This helps you to project confidence and express positive emotions freely.
- Compliment 3 people daily or express your appreciation. This reduces fear of judgment and builds positive connections.
- Reflect occasionally, but don't scrutinize yourself every moment.

KEY QUOTES

"When we overreact to negative feedback or criticism, we are likely to conclude that not only is our present course slightly off beam, or wrong, but that it is wrong for us to even want to go forward."

"Personality...is not so much something that is acquired from without, as something that is released from within."

"You become too careful to make a good impression, and in so doing choke off, restrain, inhibit your creative self and end up making a rather poor impression."

"The path to the goal is a course between too much inhibition and too little."

"The inhibited personality is as afraid of expressing 'good' feelings as bad ones."



Breaking Free From Conditioned Responses



Often, we develop unhelpful habitual responses to certain stimuli. For example, we may reflexively answer a distracting phone call even when we're in the middle of an important task.



Use relaxation to break free from these conditioned responses:

- Studies found that full relaxation makes it impossible to feel negative emotions. It serves as an effective mental shield against habitual responses, to either ignore or delay your response to the stimuli.
- Think of it as a “spiritual thermostat” that regulates your reaction and maintains emotional stability. This helps you to handle any situation in a calm and composed way, instead of being controlled by your emotions.



One way to relax is by creating a quiet space in your mind that you can retreat to any time.

- Imagine a serene room designed with elements that bring you peace—such as simple furnishings, calm colors, or a calming view.
- Whenever you feel a negative emotion, or feel stressed or stuck, visualize yourself entering this space, relaxing, and taking a mental break.
- You can also use this space to clear your mind before starting on an important challenge or interaction, to prevent negative emotions from being carried from one event to another.



Thriving Under Crisis



Crises can either hold you back or help you to grow—depending on how you respond to it. To perform well in crisis, you need to:

- Practice without pressure: It's ineffective to learn under pressure. Repeatedly practice critical skills beforehand, in a calm and pressure-free setting, until they become automatic and will come to you naturally even in high-stress situations.

KEY QUOTES

“Today, more than ever, it's vital to address the bad habit of overresponse—to relax from doing—when we are assaulted by the stimuli of email, texts, and all manner of electronic communications.”

“You are basically an 'actor'—not a 'reactor'.”

“Men seek retreats for themselves: houses in the country, sea-shores and mountains...But...it is in thy power whenever thou shalt choose to retire into thyself.”
—Marcus Aurelius

“The real problem is not to control emotion, but to control the choice of which tendency shall receive emotional reinforcement.”
—Prescott Lecky

“The more intense the crisis situation under which you learn, the less you learn.”

- A crisis can unleash hidden energy and abilities to propel you forward. During a crisis, stay focused on your goals so you can deliberately channel your energy toward creative solutions that support those goals (rather than succumb to fear or stress).
- See the crisis in perspective. Ask yourself, what's the worst thing that can happen? When you consider the implications calmly, you'll probably realize that things aren't as bad as they seem.



Conclusion and Other Details in the Book



Self-image is powerful, and it can be changed to positively impact all aspects of your life. Once your mind is tuned for success, you'll naturally experience a "winning feeling" that helps you to act with confidence and spontaneity. To build this winning feeling:

- Start small and build up gradually. Begin with manageable tasks, and let every small victory build confidence and momentum.
- Replay successes: Mentally revisit past success, even minor ones, to boost your confidence and set the stage for more wins.
- Practice positive visualization: Instead of worrying about failure, mentally rehearse successful outcomes to reinforce positive beliefs, build courage and confidence.
- Manage negative emotions: You can choose how to respond to negative feelings like fear and doubt—use them to fuel to progress, rather than let them paralyze you.
- Rewrite your mental script: Replace memories of past failures with present successes, and change how you interpret past events to build self-esteem and resilience.



This book includes many other examples and studies of people who have successfully transformed their lives by applying the tools/tips above to change their self-image. For more details, please visit www.psychocybernetics.com.

KEY QUOTES

"If we can...react aggressively instead of negatively to threats and crises, the very situation itself can act as a stimulus to release untapped powers."

"Call up, capture, evoke the feeling of success. When you feel successful and self-confident, you will act successfully. When the feeling is strong, you can literally do no wrong."

"You are not 'inferior.' You are not 'superior.' You are simply 'You.'...You are not 'supposed' to be like any other person and no other person is 'supposed' to be like you."